

Carolina Outdoors

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CAROLINA RAPTOR CENTER

by Bob Holland

Where else is your conversation interrupted by a comical looking vulture tugging at your shoelaces? Comical looking? Aren't vultures dangerous, repulsive birds? Not Campbell. He and over 150 other raptors (birds of prey) now belong to one large family at Latta Plantation Park in northern Mecklenburg County. Campbell's home is The Carolina Raptor Center, and it exists because of the energy and imagination of Dr. Richard Brown.

Richard Brown began to develop the idea for a raptor rehabilitation project almost fifteen years ago. Until recently he was a professor at UNC-Charlotte, but he has resigned his position to devote all his energy to the raptor project. At present, the Raptor Center is operating at their eighty acres on Mountain Island Lake, housed in two trailers. The birds live in a series of outdoor chain link pens. Dr.

Brown envisions a 22,000 square foot building with a visitor's center, and ample space for research and convalescent care for injured birds. For the present, he and a seven-member Board of Directors are working to get two more trailers, drill a well and install a septic tank. A small cadre of dedicated volunteers supplies all the labor, but more hands are needed.

Campbell is a lifer. He'll never fly free, find a mate, migrate above the Appalachians. Someone snatched him from his nest only to throw him in a convenience store dumpster. The store owner took pity on him, fed him Campbell Soup (hence his name) then called Richard Brown to the rescue. All of this happened during a critical period in the young bird's life when many species are "imprinted". Campbell imprinted on humans, and now he'll never know how to act like a vulture.

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Melinda Welton, Endangered Species Biologist, and a "hacker" with one of the peregrine chicks at the beginning of the Grandfather Peregrine Program.



PEREGRINES ON GRANDFATHER

by Kay Scott

High atop the crags of Grandfather Mountain's backcountry, peregrine falcons once again soar through Carolina blue skies. These falcons are the focus of a project to restore this endangered species to its once-native Western North Carolina habitat.

Six peregrine falcon chicks arrived at Grandfather Mountain on May 20. The chicks were obtained from The Peregrine Fund, a Cornell University based non-profit organization which breeds captive falcons and releases their young into the wild.

The 35 day old chicks spent their first seven days as Tar Heel residents in a cage perched on the cliffs of Grandfather Mountain.

On the 42nd day of their life, the cage door was opened and the birds were allowed free access to the spectacular skies of Western North Carolina.

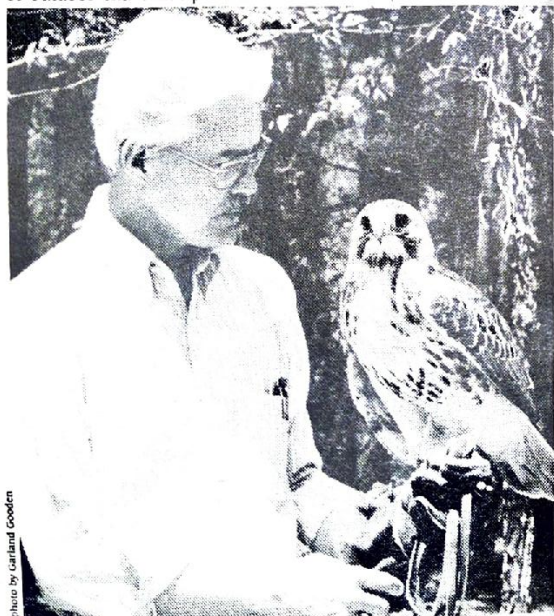
The North Carolina Wildlife Resources Commission, through its Nongame and Endangered Wildlife Program, is coordinating this restoration project. Commission biologists refer to this as a 'hacking project.' Melinda Welton, Endangered Species Project Leader for the Nongame and Endangered Wildlife Program explains: "During a hacking project, four to five young birds, about five weeks old, are brought to the site. While there, they remain in an enclosed hack cage

located on a cliff face for between one and two weeks while they mature and reach flight capability. Then, with the least disturbance possible, they are released."

"Food is provided at the hack cage for an additional four to eight weeks," according to Welton. "The food is provided by falcon attendants who stay out of sight of the birds, near the hack site, for the duration of the project."

Hacking is a successful method of reintroducing peregrines to an area because young birds of prey who learn to fly and hunt in a particular area will re-

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Dr. Richard Brown with Sigmund, a mature female red-tail hawk.

Campbell eyeballs a tempting shoeace. A "Luer, Campbell will never fly free.

Carolina Raptor Center

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Some of Campbell's avian companions are lifers too. Wings shot away by careless hunters, injured in collisions with cars, maimed in the jaws of a trap, these beautiful birds will never be able to live on their own. Others are only at the Center for a time of rest and healing, or perhaps an operation donated by one of several dedicated veterinarians who work with the center.

The birds at the Raptor Center come from all across North America. There are more than a dozen other such facilities, most of them willing to exchange birds for research and education. There are hawks here which are native to the Southwest, and a mated pair of Golden Eagles, once found in this region but now extremely rare. One of Dr. Brown's plans calls for captive breeding of birds like the Golden Eagles to supply young birds for release in

areas such as our own where they have long since been driven away. Another project involves building artificial nest platforms for Ospreys to be installed on nearby lakes and rivers.

The ultimate goal of the Carolina Raptor Center is public education to further the growing awareness that all life forms are part of a vast network, with each creature's well being dependent on that of all the rest. To this end, Dr. Brown's plans for a future environmental center include an innovative approach: The world as seen through the eyes of an eagle and an owl.

Plan a weekend visit. You'll have a closeup look at some beautiful wild birds and a chance to take part in the birth of a valuable institution. Admission and parking are free and memberships fees or donations are tax deductible.



N



nesting pairs of peregrines. During the late 40's and early 50's this population declined. In fact, the last record of nesting pere-

grines in this state was in 1958. In 1984, the first year of the program, North Carolina citizens contributed about

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photo by Jack Dermid

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"This decline in numbers was a nationwide phenomenon strongly related to the development and use of chlorinated hydrocarbon pesticides, such as DDT, from the late 40's until 1972," commented Welton. "The banning of DDT in 1972, along with the education of the public about the value of raptors has made this former habitat once again suitable for peregrines."

The Commission hopes to have three active release sites next year. Criteria for the potential sites is strict—mountains high

enough so that Great Horned Owls do not feed in the area, a remote site with controlled human access and the presence of high cliffs. According to Welton, "Peregrine chicks are a favorite 'lunch' for Great Horned Owls. So, the site must have an altitude great enough to avoid such confrontations. In addition, to be successful, the hacking process must assure that the birds have very little human contact. This will help to insure their success in the wild."

Areas under consideration for the additional hacking sites in-

clude the Linville Gorge Wilderness Area, an area near Highlands and a potential urban release site. The United States Forest Service has been a major cooperator in locating sites for future hacking projects. All release sites are limited to Western North Carolina since this is the extent of the bird's historic range.

"Grandfather Mountain has provided a perfect site for the two hacking projects," said Welton. "Because of the developed wilderness program providing a relatively remote backcountry location with limited human access, we have a greater probability of successful restoration to this area. In addition, the staff at Grandfather Mountain has been tremendously supportive and extremely helpful."

Costs associated with the peregrine hacking projects are considerable. Release of the six birds on Grandfather will cost the Commission's Nongame and Endangered Wildlife Fund about \$8,000. This figure includes the cost of birds, transportation, feeding and the salaries of the two observers. However, it does not include the cost of the salaries of Commission personnel associated with the project.

Peregrine restoration has been extremely successful in other areas of the country. For example, in the Northeast, about 600 birds have been released and more than 30 breeding pairs have been established in that area.

